close exploration of this site of Holocaust memory to the plight of diasporic people of color in Germany. In doing so, Lorde connected her reflection on the history and memory of the Holocaust in Berlin to her Afro-diasporic consciousness.

Inspired by this journal entry and shared identifications, Lorde typed out drafts on February 2 and February 19, 1985, and continued to revisit the concept and edit the poem toward publication.[68] In the poem, Lorde marks this memorial as a site of contradiction rather than resolution. Lorde's poem conjures Claude Lanzmann's film *Shoah* by placing her vision of the site of memory around the "overgrowth" of nature and amnesiac cultures over sites of Holocaust trauma.[69] She also uses geographic space to signify historical time. Lorde's earliest drafts carry the titles "Plotenzee Memorial to the Resistance: Berlin 1984" and "Plotensee Memorial_Berlin 1984."[70] In the final draft, she makes two key changes: the primary title is a translation of the actual plaque inscription at the memorial ("Diese Urne Enthält Erde aus deutschen Konzentrationslagern"), which she had also cited in an early draft of the poem, and the geopolitical descriptive "West" is added to Berlin in the title. In the latter case, she recalls the specific location of the site, as well as how Germany's post–1945 division created spaces of historic estrangement and sublimated traumas of the recent past. Through all the iterations, her use of the year in the title reminds readers of the influence of her first trip but also resembles an inscriptive timestamp often found on historical markers or printed photographs, as if to retrieve the site from a frozen past and bring it toward an active present.

The poem opens with a tension staged between remembrance and erasure. Lorde begins with a recounting of the memorial's architectural features (a "stone wall," and parts of the memorial's actual inscription in her poem) set against memorial elements added to the site ("self-conscious wreaths/the heavy breath of gaudy Berlin roses") in order to convey the gaps between what is presented and what is rendered silent in this historical scene. Her references to a "stone wall" and "self-conscious wreaths" also conjure the Berlin Wall and place President Reagan's 1985 Bitburg cemetery controversy within the context of the problematic nature of Holocaust memory. "The heavy breath of gaudy Berlin roses" further suggests the empty expressive gestures of beauty in the face of a misremembered history. She compares the stone wall to the height of her daughter, personalizing her view of the historic site. The memorial, Lorde characterizes by the word